



are just beginning their education, learning Braille through hand-holding can be challenging and may affect their confidence and development.

To make their education more accessible and advanced, Thinkerbell Labs has developed a unique device called 'Annie.' This innovative tool helps visually impaired children read, write, and type in Braille. Designed for ages 4 to 15, Annie uses gamified learning to make Braille education engaging and effective. The device supports multiple languages and has been deployed in over 150 centres across India and internationally.

Originally named Project Mudra, Thinkerbell Labs drew inspiration from Bell Labs, symbolising innovation. Their flagship product, Annie, is named after Helen Keller's teacher.

Dilip asserts that a team of 50 employees manages the complete engineering process for Annie internally, encompassing hardware, software, and content. The product has undergone multiple iterations, incorporating feedback from Braille teachers, students, and rehabilitation organisations. Thinkerbell Labs collaborates with contract manufacturers for components, with final assembly and quality control conducted in Bengaluru. The company also

works with global organisations like RNIB in the UK for curriculum development.

The startup has collaborated with various government agencies to promote Braille education and seeks policy support to integrate digital Braille learning tools in mainstream and

inclusive schools.

Thinkerbell Labs works closely with government agencies, philanthropic organisations, and CSR initiatives to fund the deployment of its devices in schools. It provides schools with login mechanisms, analytics through Helios, and a comprehensive learning ecosystem. Internationally, the company partners with distributors, while in India, sales are managed by its team, with some pilot partnerships with channel partners.

The startup also exports Annie to countries like the US, UK, Australia, New Zealand, and parts of the Gulf. Although its primary operations are based in Bengaluru, it has an office

in Abu Dhabi to support its Gulf market efforts.

Thinkerbell Labs has raised approximately 100 to 120 million rupees through friends, family, angel investments, small VCs, government grants, and prize money from business plan competitions. "The funding has been crucial in overcoming design and business challenges, from creating a new product category to convincing target audiences of the value of digital Braille learning," explains Dilip.

They have sold over 1000 units in India and approximately 1200 units in the US. Sales in other regions began just two months ago, with around 100 units sold so far. It is expected that this number will rise soon as the new markets gain traction.

The startup has experienced 80% revenue growth year-on-year, closing the previous year at around 115 million rupees. They anticipate continued growth in the range of 1.5 to 2x annually. The company is conducting research on new products to assist visually impaired students beyond Braille literacy, potentially addressing broader educational needs. However, no immediate announcements are planned.

Aman, Sanskriti, and Dilip were classmates, and Saif, also from BITS Pilani, was their junior by one year. The team initially worked on their product as a research project and gained momentum after attending a conference in Canada, where they identified a market need for their innovation. They started prototyping and building their product during their final semester, leading to the company's establishment in Bengaluru. The support from mentors and investors like Rajesh Nominatim and Anand Mahindra has been instrumental in their journey. **EFY**

—Nitisha Dubey



Dilip Ramesh, Co-founder and CTO, Thinkerbell Labs